Assessment and Feedback Policy

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RELEVANT DOCUMENTS

N/A

RELATED POLICIES & DOCUMENTS

List here any internal policies or documents that are relevant to this policy e.g.

- Academic Framework Regulations
- Curriculum Development Guide
- Learning and Teaching Plan

Assessment and Feedback Policy

This document relates to assessment and feedback for all LJMU students. The policy is organised into sections that follows a typical assessment workflow: principles of assessment and feedback, preparation and design of summative assessments, the assessment period and moderation of summative assessments. Please visit the assessment and feedback guidance website that provides additional support for this policy.

Principles of Assessment and Feedback

The Assessment and Feedback Policy works the following core principles:

- **Equitability:** LJMU assessment and feedback should provide all students with a fair and equitable opportunity to meet assessment criteria.
- **Transparency:** All LJMU assessments should be written and communicated in such a way to be transparent to all students to help them understand what is required, how they will be assessed and provided with feedback.
- **Anticipatory:** Assignments should be accessible in the sense of enabling all students, irrespective of physical disability/learning differences, to meet assessment criteria. Students must be supported in their understanding, development and submission of assessment items.
- **Flexibility:** Alternative assessment provides a framework to meet the diverse needs of our students.
- **Accountability:** All assessment design, feedback and marking must conform to LJMU curriculum standards and procedures as defined in the Academic Framework Regulations.
- **Collaborative:** Where possible, students should be enabled and encouraged to contributed to assessment design, the development of marking criteria or choice of feedback methods.

Policy Statements

This policy applies to all students on LJMU taught programmes including those delivered by partners.

Preparation and Design of Summative Assessments

Learning outcomes: Assessment tasks and criteria must be aligned to relevant learning outcomes to ensure that students who pass the module, the level and the programme have met the intended learning outcomes. Assessment should not over assess any learning outcomes.

Internal approval: Summative assessments are validated as part of the 'Module Proforma' and amended only with the approval of the designated School and Faculty authorities.

External approval:
External examiners are required to approve the form and content (i.e. the assessment specification and detail) of all summative assessments and marking criteria at all levels. This is required for each offering of the module (i.e. each time the module is delivered) and is required prior to the delivery of the module. External examiners should also approve any alternative assessment offered to students. External examiner approval is required prior to the publication of assessment information to students.

Changes to the validated assessment information, detailed within the module proforma, (such as but not limited to, an increase in weighting or permanent amendment of the assessment type, e.g. essay to exam) must be submitted for consideration and approval to the Programme and Module Amendment Panel (PMAP). In such instances, the external examiner must be informed of any proposed change(s), and offered the opportunity to comment, but is not required to approve the change.

Clear assessment criteria: All assessments must have defined marking criteria, published in advance and prior to the delivery of the module. Students must be assessed against these criteria and feedback should specifically relate to them.

Information about criteria should be clear and explicit. Students should be able to understand and use the feedback that they are given by explicitly relating it back to the criteria for the assessment task. Marking criteria should align with the LJMU grading descriptors. The latter are generic statements of required standards, and marking criteria need to explain specific expectations related to the assessment.

All programmes must have a feedback strategy: The purpose of feedback (be it diagnostic, formative or summative) and how and when it will be provided should be made clear at the start of the module. This relates to all assessment types, including examinations. This needs to be transparent to students in the module information on the VLE and explained in programme review. This should include a rationale for the range of assessments and the organisation of submission deadlines.

Formative Feedback: It is recommended that module leaders and teams provide opportunities for students to get formative feedback on their work. Formative feedback is guidance provided on students' work before final submission to help them identify gaps in their learning and improve their performance. Where this is provided, steps should be taken to ensure that students have equal access for formative feedback opportunities. Further information and examples can be found in the Assessment and Feedback Guidance.

Continuous Assessment: It is also recommended that module leaders and teams should consider the possible value of offering sequential summative assessment submissions over the whole teaching period and not just at the end of the module. This will scaffold student learning and allow students to develop key skills as the module progresses. Guidance can be found in Continuous Assessment and Reducing Deadline Bunching.

Academic misconduct guidance: Assessment guidance should explain the consequence of, and penalties associated with, academic misconduct.

The use of Generative Artificial Intelligence (GenAI) in assessment.

Please note that this policy distinguishes between Assistive AI and Generative AI tools. The former makes suggestions, corrections and possible improvements to an author's text. Such tools are built into many programmes such as MSWord or may be standalone. The use of such tools is permitted for all assessment that is presented in a digital format.

Generative AI tools produce content, whether in the form of text, images or translations. Even if the author makes changes to the content afterwards, the content would be considered "AI-generated" if a GenAI tool such as ChatGPT was was the primary creator of the content.

The following key principles apply to the use of GenAI:

1. The university will support students and staff to become secure in the appropriate use of GenAI.
2. Where appropriate, the university will ensure that teaching and assessment approaches incorporate the ethical use of GenAI and support equal access.
3. The university will ensure academic rigour and integrity is upheld.

Assignment briefs can provide guidance on the appropriate use of GenAI. Prohibiting the use of GenAI is only possible for specific assessments approaches where the use of technology is not feasible (e.g. a live performance or viva) or can be blocked/prevented (e.g. an invigilated examination). If no guidance is available, it will be assumed that the use of any GenAI is acceptable, and students should acknowledge its use in line with the University's referencing standards.

Students will confirm the following statement at the point of coursework submission.

- "My work has been produced in accordance with instructions on the use of Gen A provided in the assessment brief for this assignment.
- Where the use of GenAI is permitted, I confirm that:

- I have not used Gen AI to gain an unfair advantage in this assessment and confirm that this work is my own.
- I understand the risks and limitations associated with Gen AI, including bias, inaccuracy, inappropriate content and ethical issues.
- I have not submitted any personally identifiable information to a Gen AI tool.
- I confirm that no part of this assessment copies Gen AI output without acknowledgement."

Students will also confirm the following statement at the point of coursework submission.

- "I confirm that I am fit to attempt this assessment

Alternative assessments: Any alternative assessment should be of an equivalent level and standard to the original assessment. It must assess the same learning outcomes as the original assessment. The University expects that an appropriate alternative to the standard assessment is available for students who are unable to undertake the standard assessment due to a long-term illness, disability, or personal circumstances. Any alternative assessment provided as a reasonable adjustment for a student with a long-term medical condition or disability must be appropriate for that student's condition. Alternative assessment should be approved by the External Examiner. For further guidance please see Inclusive Assessments

Group work: Marking schema for all group assessments must facilitate differentiation between individual students' performance. In the context of this policy, a 'group' is defined as two or more students who are working on a single assignment. A single group mark cannot be attributed as standard to all students. There is additional guidance on group work assessments in the Assessment and Feedback Guidance.

Student assessment and feedback deadlines must be published on the VLE: Programme and module information should specify a feedback deadline alongside assessment submission deadlines. Clustering of

assessment deadlines should be avoided. Guidance for reducing clustering is available in Continuous Assessment and Reducing Deadline Bunching.

Online submission: Where feasible, work should be submitted electronically via the VLE. If submission of hard copy documents or artefacts is required, mechanisms should be in place so that students are not financially disadvantaged by this. Assignment guidelines should include clear instruction on the submission process.

Use of digital technology for completion of assessment tasks: Students must receive support to ensure they can access and use any technology required for the purposes of assessment. All students should have the same opportunity of access and be treated equally regarding monitoring or processing of submissions.

Second marker/moderator: Other than instances where moderation is managed through Standardisation, a second marker or moderator should be identified before the module is delivered where possible. Ideally, this will be a colleague who also teaches on the module or a member of the programme team.

During the assessment period

Alternative assessment: Alternative assessment refers to a change to the assessment strategy that is deemed necessary to ensure that equitable treatment for students. Alternative assessments must meet all relevant learning outcomes and should not give any student an unfair advantage or disadvantage over their peers.

Students with long-term medical conditions or disabilities: Students who have disclosed to the University (or Partner College) a long-term medical condition or disability may have a needs assessment. This will identify the type of support required and signal any reasonable adjustment. The Individual Student Learning Plan (or its equivalent in a Partner College) may specify a range of suitable measures, such as additional time in examinations or flexible deadlines. There is an obligation on the module leader to make appropriate reasonable

adjustments for the assessments on their modules. Students with an Individual Student Learning Plan should be assessed in accordance with that where practicable. The school disability coordinator or the central disability support team (or its equivalent in a Partner College) can offer advice regarding suitable alternatives. These may differ from those suggested on the Individual Student Learning Plan if they remain appropriate to the student's condition.

Alternative assessment for all students on a module: In very exceptional circumstances where there are operational reasons that prevent the original, validated, assessment occurring as scheduled, or there have been material irregularities with an assessment, an alternative assessment may be given to all students on the module. The decision to offer a replacement alternative assessment to an entire cohort needs approval from the faculty Assistant Academic Registrar.

Reasons for not offering an alternative assessment: There are very few circumstances when it would not be possible to offer an alternative assessment. Professionally accredited or regulated programmes may have prescribed assessment types. In these cases, the programme leader should contact the PSRB to establish whether an alternative is permitted. In addition, alternatives can be rejected if they are deemed impractical or unnecessarily expensive. This would need to be agreed with the assistant academic registrar.

Anonymous marking: All summative assessment that contribute more than 20% to the final module mark should be marked through an anonymised process. This includes coursework and open book, seen or unseen paper examination. Here is more guidance about anonymous marking.

Anonymised marking exemptions: Exemptions to Anonymised marking are as follows:

- Assessments in which students cannot remain anonymous because they are observed, e.g., presentations, performances, laboratory work, clinical practice.
- Assessments in which the production of the work has been closely supervised by the marker, e.g., art and design work, dissertation, thesis.
- Assessments where the code of practice for a professionally accredited course would be contravened if marking were anonymised.
- Where programme teams wish to provide individual, personalised feedback on summative assessment. Staff on these programmes should consult with student representatives to explain these exceptions.

Students can request access to comments: Please note that General Data Protection Regulation (2018) permits students to access any comments or internal correspondence about their work, whether made by internal or external examiners on any coursework. With respect to examination scripts, GDPR does not afford students the right of access, but the university is obliged to make staff annotations available in a meaningful and intelligible form.

Feedback: Feedback will normally be available 15 working days after the assessment deadline. Working days exclude Saturday and Sunday, bank holidays and any other day when the University is closed. Personal annual leave is deemed a working day. Note that feedback on final year, final semester examinations, except where a part-time student is taking such an examination and is continuing to study in the next academic year. In addition, dissertations/large projects are also exempt from this requirement.

Note that feedback deadlines do not apply in instances where students are unable to submit their work by the advertised deadline. In such cases, relevant academic staff are encouraged to provide feedback in a timely manner, but it is recognised that working to a 15-day timeframe may no longer feasible in relation to other workload commitments.

Students should receive in person or online face-to-face feedback on their first piece of assessed work: Programme and module teams must provide an early opportunity in each year of study for students to receive face-to-face feedback on their first piece of assessed work. This does not have to be in a one-to-one meeting. Feedback could be given in a group setting such as a tutorial, but the opportunity must be provided for students to discuss feedback on their work.

Coursework referral (and deferral) assessments

Coursework referral (and deferral) assessments should be fully published on Canvas by the relevant Results Notification Day; these may include requiring students to re-work their original assessment submission. If referral

assessments are published for all students on a module, then a disclaimer should be added, e.g. “[This assignment] is only relevant to students who have not yet passed and have attempts remaining. If unsure, please contact your Personal Tutor.”

Moderation of summative assessments and workflow

All assessment must be internally and externally moderated prior to ratification at the examination board.

Internal moderation

The purpose of moderation is to check and agree the academic standards of student assessed work and is an important quality assurance process. Traditionally this has been through scrutiny of assessment decisions that have already been made. However, more recent conceptualisations suggest a broader range of strategies that can take place before, during or after marking has taken place.

Moderation of summative assessment at all levels of study is required and will take the form of **one** of the following approaches below. The use of ongoing calibration activity (see below) to support these approaches and ensure consistency of standards on and across programmes is also encouraged.

1. **Pre-marking Standardisation**: This approach is suitable for assessment components on modules where there are multiple assessors. The purpose is to agree the academic standards through consensus seeking dialogue based on concrete examples of work. In practice this where, prior to marking, all the assessors independently judge a sample (typically three pieces) of student work and then discuss as a group the academic standards in relation to the assessment criteria. Following this process, the assessors proceed to mark the work of the full cohort based on these shared standards.

2. **Post-marking Confirmation**: This approach is suitable for assessment components on modules with only one assessor. The purpose is for a

colleague to check and ideally discuss the marking standards with the assessor. The second assessor selects a sample (10% or n=10, whichever is the greater) across the range of marks to review. Work in this sample should include both the mark and feedback. The second assessor does not provide additional feedback to students.

The marks from the first assessor will be confirmed unless:

- The second assessor identifies inconsistent application of the assessment criteria by the first assessor. In this case, the work of the whole cohort should be remarked.
- The judgement of the first and second assessor are consistently different (i.e. +/- 5%). In this case, he two assessors should agree the marks and identical scaling should be applied to the entire cohort's work. The merit order must not be changed by the scaling process. Disagreements that cannot be resolved by the two markers will require arbitration by the module/programme leader.

3. **Independent Double Marking**: This approach is suitable for dissertations/major projects or their equivalents that have a value of at least 40 credits and are normally at Level 6 and Level 7. The purpose is for the work to be independently marked by two assessors and then to agree the academic standard and final mark. The process for coming to an agreed mark should be consistent and transparent.

Moderation of non-standard assessment items: If an assessment does not involve the production of physical evidence, as with some types of performance or presentation, markers must make clear what processes are in place to ensure consistency of marking and maintenance of standards. For example, presentations and performances could be recorded and examples shared and discussed at a meeting convened for that purpose. Where double marking has been considered and is not possible, the module handbook should indicate what moderation procedures are used instead.

Calibration Activities: Moderation should be underpinned by ongoing calibration within programme teams but also across teams and where possible externally. Calibration is about the professional development of assessors to clarify and agree academic standards of student performances. This aims to go beyond the specific piece of work under consideration and support more consistent judgements that are representative of the subject community to which they belong. Further information and examples can be found in the Assessment and Feedback Guidance.

External moderation

External moderation provides an external perspective on the internal academic standards. The purpose is to ensure that marking reflects sector-wide national standards for relevant disciplines/subject areas.

Module leaders or teams must provide information to the external examiner that explains how internal moderation has been managed for their module.

External examiner role: The external examiner will be provided with access to assessed work in a timely manner to allow them to undertake the external moderation process. Ideally, the external examiner should have access to all work. Where this is not feasible, a sample of sufficient size that crosses the range of marks should be provided (10% or n=10, whichever is the greater). This will enable the external examiner to establish whether student performance has been judged appropriately against the standards. The approach to internal moderation must be clear to the external examiner.

External examiners must ensure that assessments are conducted within the approved Academic Framework Regulations, comment on the effectiveness of the assessment and are expected to attend Boards of Examiners.

Oversight of moderation

- The completion of the module mark verification report forms part of the evidence that internal and external moderation has taken place. The mark verification interface is in WebHub and the module leader must confirm

that moderation has taken place by completing the module mark verification report in relation to several prompts.

- Oversight of all marking and moderation activity is invested in Boards of Examiners. Prior to a Board of Examiners, the Director/Director's Nominee is responsible for ensuring that procedures are followed regarding the consideration and approval of the form and content of all summative assessments that count towards the assessment of the programme and its module(s). The Director/Director's Nominee is also responsible for the completion of the moderation process, for ensuring that marks achieved by students for each summative assessment task are finalised by the deadline and that External Examiners have been involved in the moderation process.

Moderation of modules studied in collaborative partner institutions.

Moderation of modules studied in collaborative partners should be done on a risk-based approach. Normally this would mean that LJMU staff would be involved with pre-marking standardisation or post marking confirmation activities in the first year of the partnership. Depending on the outcome of moderation and the stability of provision, it might be possible to delegate most of the moderation to the collaborative partner in subsequent years. If this is the case, there would still be the expectation that annual risk assessments would take place to ensure that LJMU staff are confident that the moderation process is robust and in line with LJMU standards.

Definitions

Summative assessment: Summative assessments are conducted for the purposes of awarding credit, the right to progress through a programme of study, or of determining a final award.

Moderation: Moderation is a process to ensure that marking is consistent, fair and aligned with criteria, irrespective of whether the summative assessment is taken at the first or any subsequent opportunity.

Second marker: The purpose of the second marker is to ensure consistency by independently reviewing the marks awarded by the first marker(s) for a sample of work.

Double marking: Where two individuals independently mark the same piece of work.

Feedback: Feedback should be aligned to assessment criteria, outline positive attributes and constructively alert the student to where improvements are needed.

Plagiarism prevention and detection software: The Turnitin service allows individual student's work to be uploaded and automatically matched for similarity with content on the web; certain electronic journals; and all assignments uploaded by LJMU and the other institutions using the service.

Personal circumstances: Students with personal circumstances that affect their ability to complete a scheduled assessment may request an alternative assessment. However, consideration should be given for an extension to a coursework deadline and rescheduling of the assessment to the next available assessment period (deferral)

Anonymity: Anonymity means that the marker does not know the identity of the student whose work they are marking. It ends when the final overall mark/grade

is made available via the VLE (Virtual Learning Environments) (Canvas) or transcribed to a marksheet.

Alternative assessment: An alternative assessment will assess the relevant learning outcomes to the same standard and at the same level as the standard assessment. Alternative can relate to the mode of assessment (i.e., providing and adaptation to the standard approach) or method (i.e., assessing using a completely different approach)